

rummy/poker — they would get monetary rewards in return.

It is this that the government has banned, giving the following reasons: Addiction and financial ruin, mental health and suicides, fraud and money laundering, threat to national security and closing legal loopholes.

Ashwini Vaishnaw, the Minister for Electronics and Information Technology, said that according to an estimate, 45 crore people were negatively affected by these games and consequently suffered losses of more than Rs. 20,000 crores.

MOMENT UNDER THE SUN FOR ESPORTS

The shut door to RMG has also opened an opportunity for esports — an avenue where prize money comes through competitions, like any other conventional sporting event.

In the world's biggest mobile game market — with 8.45 Billion Downloads in FY 2024-25, according to Sensor Tower's India: Mobile Game Market Insights 2025 — that is almost a jackpot.

India ranked within the top 20 countries in the world in FIFAe in 2022. Danial Shakeel Patel reached the semifinals of the 2024 Esports World Cup, while Pavan Kampelli became the first Indian to win a medal — bronze — at the Asian Esports Games last year.

The government, too, has tread the path to encourage esports.

"The Central Government shall take steps as it considers necessary to recognise and register e-sports with the Authority or agency, as the case may be, as a legitimate form of competitive sport in India and to promote and develop e-sports," the Online Gaming Act states.

At the organisers' level, there has been progress too — S8UL became the first Indian club to become a partner at the 2025 Esports World Cup.

The Battlegrounds Mobile India Masters Series (BGMS) has attracted viewership of over 100



million, comparable to physical sports.

"In India, right now, in BGMI, we're the third-most watched sport on *Star Sports*, after cricket and Kabaddi. If you have such a high viewership, the world will notice," says Akshat Rathee (left), the co-founder and managing director of NODWIN Gaming, which hosts the event.

He also adds that the continued success of the Esports World Cup will only add to the cause.

"The Esports World Cup just recently announced the Nations Cup, which is among countries (as units and not individual players) and in November 2026, while keeping the Esports World Cup in the summer season," he adds.

"I also think AI-enabled content creation, social media platforms around esports, travel around esports, hospitality, teams, education, training, athletes, gyms — so much of that industry is still unexplored."

While esports felt left out when it was excluded from the National Sports Governance Bill, it surely gets its moment in the sun now — to carve out a new path in a growing and promising market.



Did you know? Brazil and Real Madrid forward Vinicius Junior is a co-owner of Brazilian esports organisation, LOUD, which fields teams in League of Legends, Free Fire, and Valorant.



WHO AM I?

I started my BGMI career with Global Esports in 2022, and my professional journey has taken me to Revenant XSpark and back to Team SouL, establishing me as one of India's top BGMI talents. Who am I? The answer will be revealed in the next issue.



Answer to previous issue's quiz:
Jeet "Swifty" Kundra

BUSINESS OF ESPORTS

NODWIN Gaming became the majority shareholder of the longest-running fighting game event, Evo (Evolution Championship Series), after acquiring Sony Interactive Entertainment's stake for an undisclosed amount.



EASTER EGG 'CASTER'

Caster is the esports equivalent of a commentator in a normal sporting event. Usually, there are two casters for an esports event.

Rankings and quiz powered by NODWIN Gaming